

Lately

You know those calendars you get from the Asian supermarket in January? The ones where you can tear off a sheet of translucent paper every morning to track your progress through the year? Lately, the days have seemed like each page has flown onto my body, sticking to my skin like I'm some twisted papier-mâché exhibit.

I get asked when it started, and I can never say. The layers are so thin you don't notice them get stuck to your arms and legs. You only notice after it builds up to the point where you can't move anymore, frozen in this sticky mess of time and feelings and snot and tears.

If I had to give it a guess, though, I'd say mid-May. Which really sucks because the sun is out and the birds are chirping and the air is fragrant with flowers so I should be happy but I'm not.

My therapist will tell me that it's because I'm about to "embark on an exciting new chapter of my life" (which makes sense because Spring is all about fresh beginnings and everything), but this feels different. I know how grief hurts. Grief is deep within my body. It is jagged and mobile, constantly finding new tissue in my heart to puncture and new parts of my ribs to crack. This was a growing sense of apathy. Too bad the papier-mâché coated my fingers before I could peel the pages off from the rest of my body.

So there I was, lying helpless in my bed for a good couple of weeks. I started sleeping later and waking up just as late—you know, the works. The cast made it difficult to do anything besides the essentials, like eating, which I needed to do desperately.

I rifle through the email I use specifically for promotions (who wants spam on their normal email?) and see that Wingstop is offering free delivery every Wednesday for the entire month. Woah! I love Wingstop. So I text my roommate (who also loves Wingstop):

What are you eating for dinner tonight

WHY

PLS

DONT SAY IT

WINGSTOP??????

FREE DELIVERY

I HAVE NO MONEY

...

And then she barges into my room and asks me if I'd want to cook with her that night instead. It's the perfect plan: she has frozen Korean fried chicken and I have frozen French fries. We just throw that in the oven and we can have everything we'd ever want from Wingstop. I know in my head that that's not true, but she's right about the economy. So I drag myself out of bed and preheat the oven to 350°F.

We eat together that night, taking the food right off the baking sheet and dipping it into a shared bowl of sauce. And with every piece of chicken and every fry, I swear I could feel my paper shell softening just a little.

I felt it again rocking in my hammock, under the rustling branches of the trees, listening to the soft strum of my friend's guitar.

I felt it again seeing my roommate's eyes light up when she realized our schedules aligned perfectly for us to walk home together.

I felt it again trying to chase the elusive strawberry moon with my friend, in a city I'd never before set foot in.

I felt it again squeezing the paw of that \$40 plushie I built with my girls at the mall, listening to the sounds of their voices fill my room.

I felt it again descending into silliness during a 4am video call with my boyfriend, watching him chuckle at my shenanigans.

I feel it with every hug, every high-five, every weary head on a load-bearing shoulder. I feel it with every *How was your day, Text me when you get home, I missed you.*

I feel it every time I'm with you.

I still find bits and pieces of numbered pages stuck to my body every once in a while—papier-mâché is hard to clean up. That's okay. You did all the heavy lifting for me, and you didn't even know it. I didn't even know it, until now.